

The Noble Great Dhāraṇī

Āryamahādhāraṇī · Toh 529 · Derge Kangyur

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The Noble Great Dhāraṇī, known in Sanskrit as the Āryamahādhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Pakpa Zungchenpo, is a dhāraṇī text presenting a powerful ritual formula taught by the Buddha to his disciple Ānanda. Set in the Jeta Grove at Śrāvastī, the text opens with Ānanda visiting the Buddha after completing a rains retreat, establishing a narrative frame for the transmission of this sacred dhāraṇī. As a dhāraṇī scripture, it belongs to a class of texts concerned with the recitation and protective efficacy of condensed, mantra-like formulas regarded as embodiments of the Buddha's teaching. It is catalogued as Toh 529 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of translated Buddhist scriptures.

Thus it is complete.

In the language of India: Āryamahādhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Dhāraṇī.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, in the residence of Prince Jeta, together with a great Saṅgha of one thousand two hundred and fifty monks.

At that time the venerable Ānanda completed the rains retreat in the city where he was residing. When the three months of the rains season had passed, he performed the making of the rains-robles. Having received the rains-robles, he took up his bowl and robes and went to where the Blessed One was. He arrived, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and sat down to one side.

Seated to one side, the Blessed One declared these words to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, for the sake of the welfare, benefit, happiness, strength, and splendor of all sentient beings, take up, bear, recite, retain, thoroughly master, and keep in mind these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī. And why is that? Because the root mantras of the great dhāraṇī are difficult to come by, and because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas are themselves rare to encounter in the world — like the flower of the udumbara tree. Therefore take them up, bear them, recite them, retain them, keep them in mind, and thoroughly master them.

"Ānanda, whatever son or daughter of a faithful family holds, bears, recites, retains, or thoroughly masters these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī shall not meet an untimely death by weapons. Not by poison. Not by fire. Not by water. Not by royal punishment. They shall not meet an untimely death at all. Gods, asuras, nāgas, wind-gods, garuḍas, gandharvas, kinnaras, great serpents, yakṣas, rākṣasas, hungry ghosts, flesh-eaters, kumbhāṇḍas, piśācas, decaying spirits, elemental spirits, spirits that cause forgetfulness, spirits that cause madness, oppressing spirits, shadow-afflicting spirits, spirits that bring death, and spirits that bring harm shall have no power over such a person. Neither humans nor non-humans shall have power over them. Physical actions, verbal actions, and mental actions shall have no power over them. Fevers lasting one day, two days, three days, four days, chronic fevers, fevers caused by spirits, brief fevers, fevers arising from wind, fevers arising from bile, fevers arising from phlegm, and fevers arising from their combination shall have no power over them.

"The root mantras of the great dhāraṇī are these:

Tadyathā: jvāle, mahājvāle, jvālane, mahājvālane, tāpane, mahātāpane, jvālite, ugaḡge, bugaḡge, sambhade, mahāsambhade, cakre, mahācakre — may all sentient beings and I be protected from all fears, all harms, and all contagious diseases. Svāhā.

"Ānanda, these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī were proclaimed by seventy-seven million perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, and I too now teach them and rejoice in them.

"Ānanda, whatever son or daughter of a faithful family holds, bears, recites, keeps in mind, or thoroughly masters these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī —"

— they will recall their past lives for seven lifetimes. They will not turn back from the awakening mind.

These are the root mantras of the great dhāraṇī:

Tadyathā: ante, bandhe, kṣame, kṣamame, dhānase, badane, adane, hule, mahāhule, kareṃ bhīre, duṣpuste — may all sentient beings and I be protected, protected from all fears, all harms, and all contagious diseases. Svāhā.

"Ānanda, these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī were proclaimed by eighty-eight million perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, and I too

now teach them and rejoice in them.

"Ānanda, whatever son or daughter of a faithful family holds, bears, recites, keeps in mind, or thoroughly masters these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī — they will recall their past lives for fourteen lifetimes. They will not turn back from the awakening mind.

These are the root mantras of the great dhāraṇī:

Tadyathā: aṭṭe, baṭṭe, agge, bagge, thagge, ṭhagge, dhake, dhāradhagake, ṭake ṭake, akasi, sakasi, makasi, ilimili, tilimili, raurave, mahāraurave, bhūtaṃgame, bhūtaparāyaṇe, timigise, mahātimigise, saṃbhāve, mahāsaṃbhāve — may all sentient beings and I be protected, protected from all fears, all harms, and all contagious diseases. Svāhā.

"Ānanda, these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī were proclaimed by ninety-nine million perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, and I too now teach them and rejoice in them.

"Ānanda, whatever son or daughter of a faithful family holds, bears, recites, keeps in mind, or thoroughly masters these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī — they will recall their past lives for twenty-one lifetimes. They will not turn back from the awakening mind.

These are the root mantras of the great dhāraṇī:

Tadyathā: rule, mahārule, he he ri, mattari, jambhani, stambhani —

"Ānanda, if any son or daughter of a faithful family were to take a dry piece of wood that has been protected, fully safeguarded, fully held, fully maintained, and pacified through these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī — made auspicious, freed from severance, freed from weapons, poison neutralized, poison destroyed, boundaries drawn, the sky bound, and the earth bound — and were then to bind it with a cord, even that dry wood would grow roots again, branches, leaves, shoots, flowers, and fruit. How much more needless is it to speak of a body endowed with consciousness! Ānanda, the sole exception is the ripening of prior karma.

"Ānanda, these two — the sun and the moon, renowned for such great miraculous power, such great might, such great sovereignty — could fall to the earth. The king of mountains, Mount Meru, could be shaken from its place. Ānanda, the great ocean, so deep, so vast, with such great miraculous power and might — all four of its great qualities could dry up and be utterly exhausted in the end. The great earth could shatter into a thousand pieces.

Water could abandon its quality of wetness. Fire could abandon its heat. Wind could abandon its coldness. Yet these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī cannot deceive.

"Ānanda, whether it be a god, a nāga, an asura, a garuḍa, a wind deity, a gandharva (Skt. gandharva), a human, a great serpent, a yakṣa, a rākṣasa, a hungry ghost, a flesh-eater, a vetāla, or"

a zombie, a body-zombie, an elemental spirit, a brahmin demon, a rākṣasa, a shadow-oppressor, a human, or a non-human — if any one of these, or indeed any being whatsoever, were to act in violation of these root mantras of the great dhāraṇī, then: tadyathā — agghile, caggile, balle, malle, ohāni, mohāni, jambhani, stambhani — protect, protect me and all sentient beings, svāhā. The Great King Dhṛtarāṣṭra (Guardian of the Eastern Quarter) too, with his iron wheel blazing, blazing greatly, spreading and blazing everywhere, become a single tongue of flame, shall cleave that one's head into seven pieces. The Great King Virūḍhaka (Guardian of the Southern Quarter) and Virūpākṣa (the Ill-Eyed One, Guardian of the Western Quarter) and Vaiśravaṇa (the son of Viśravan, Guardian of the Northern Quarter) too, with the iron wheel blazing, blazing greatly, spreading and blazing everywhere, become a single tongue of flame, shall cleave that one's head into seven pieces. Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), Śatakratu too, shall hurl his vajra. And the Lord of Secrets, Vajrapāṇi, too, with a vajra blazing, blazing greatly, spreading and blazing everywhere, become a single tongue of flame, shall cleave that one's head into seven pieces. That one shall have no power to remain in the royal palace Vaijayanta, and that one's head shall be split into seven pieces like the arjaka flower's seedpod.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Ānanda, together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, all the world rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had declared.

Translator's Notes

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, indicating the translated excerpt is incomplete and the text continues beyond this point.

The terms rendered as "wind-gods" and "garuḍas" translate "ཀླུ་གྲུ་མཆོག་པོ་" and "ཀླུ་གྲུ་མཆོག་པོ་མཆོག་པོ་" respectively; the latter is the standard Tibetan rendering of Skt. garuḍa. Several of the spirit-classes in the long demonological list have no transparent Sanskrit equivalents in standard sources; "kumbhāṇḍas," "piśācas," and related terms follow conventional Tibetan Buddhist identification. The number "seventy-seven million" renders the Tibetan "bye ba phrag bdun cu rtsa bdun," literally "seventy-seven ten-millions."

- The mantra syllables throughout are rendered as faithful transliterations of the Tibetan phonetic transcription of Sanskrit. Variant spellings between mantra sets are preserved as they appear in the Tibetan, consistent with the preceding section. The term rendered "great serpent" translates a Tibetan word meaning a large snake or serpent spirit distinct from the nāga class. The phrase "the sky bound and the earth bound" refers to tantric ritual boundary-setting practices. The passage ends mid-sentence as the Tibetan provided is incomplete.
- The four Great Kings named in this passage are the traditional guardians of the four quarters: Dhṛtarāṣṭra (East), Virūḍhaka (South), Virūpākṣa (West), and Vaiśravaṇa (North). The Tibetan gives them by their Tibetan equivalents, and they are rendered here by their standard Sanskrit names.

The mantra syllables are transliterated as closely as the Tibetan phonetic rendering allows; the Sanskrit Ur-text likely had slightly different forms, but no emendation has been introduced.

The plant name rendered "arjaka" is a type of basil or related herb (Sanskrit arjaka) whose fruit capsule splits into multiple segments; the simile means the head splits dramatically into seven parts.

The palace name "Vaijayanta" is the standard name for Indra's heavenly palace but is used here in context as a royal dwelling; the Tibetan lcangs lo can corresponds to this name.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.